

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1992-10-28

To two individual b ahá'ís

1 dear b ahá'í f riends,

in your letter of 15 September 1992 regarding the manner of appealing

2 to the youth and of involving them in bahá'í activities, particularly with
3 respect to the youth year of service, and we have been directed to convey
4 the following.

The house of justice sympathizes with your view that undue pressure

5 should not be put on the youth to induce them to engage in activities of
6 a youth year of service, and it certainly would not be in accord with the
7 purposes of the faith to require youth to abandon their academic training
8 so as to teach or otherwise serve the faith. many factors bear on the various
9 points you have raised; these must be understood by both youth and par-ents, and of
course by members of bahá'í institutions. for example, every
10 bahá'í, whether youth or adult, has spiritual duties and obligations in com-
11 mon; among these is the duty prescribed by bahá'u'lláh to the individual to
12 teach his faith, a duty which he describes as the "most meritorious of all
deeds" and in which he urges us to be "unrestrained as the wind."

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so, the youth must be knowledgeable of the emphasis which bahá'u'lláh

14 places on education and the acquisition of skills, and they should regard the
15 pursuit of these objectives as a service to g od.
16 particular challenges must be met by the youth, parents, and the bahá'í
17 institutions in relation to their respective responsibilities. f or instance:

18 - The youth face the pressing obligation of completing their educa-tion so as to
acquire a profession or trade while at the same time observing their other spiritual
obligations and duties to g od.

19 - p arents have the responsibility of ensuring that their children are
20 educated and, to the extent possible, must provide the material support for their
academic or vocational training up through their

youthful years; parents also continue during this period to offer

21 141-1. gwb, no. 128.10, 161.2.141.1

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15 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

00them moral and practical guidance as befits their parental duties

and with respect to the spiritual obligations which they share in

16 common with their b ahá'í children.

- The bahá'í institutions have not only to administer the affairs of

the community and protect its interests but also to stimulate and

17 exhort the friends to fulfill their spiritual duties and obligations.

These same institutions, while encouraging the friends to teach the

cause of god and to make sacrifices in so doing, also have the clear

responsibility laid upon them by bahá'u'lláh to promote education

18 of the human race, both spiritual and academic.

So fundamental are these duties and obligations that to some degree

19 all entities—youth, parents, bahá'í institutions—share in them, acting in

20 accordance with their respective functions and responsibilities. There is a sphere in
which each must make independent judgments and take indepen-dent action. A youth must
decide on what professional training to pursue and keep a balance between such pursuit and
his spiritual obligations; the

21 parents must assist the youth, through material support and moral guid-

22 ance, to achieve his goal, and must also encourage the youth in the obser-vance of his
spiritual obligations; the institutions must promote the cause

23 of god, endeavor to stimulate action on the part of individual believers in

24 the teaching and consolidation of the faith, with the full realization that if

25 such action is neglected there can be no hope for the peace of mankind and the future
growth of civilization. The institutions cannot, therefore, fail to

26 urge the friends to service and to call their attention to the critical situation

27 of the times and to point out the crucial importance of the action of the individual to
the fortunes of the faith and humanity as a whole.

28 Along with all these considerations is the factor of the special role which

29 the youth, with their particular qualities of enthusiasm and idealism, play in the
development of the cause. This has been evident from the earliest

30 days of the faith and is indispensable to its ultimate triumph. A cursory

31 review of bahá'í history provides many examples of the heroic deeds of

32 youth, and today's bahá'í youth cannot help but be inspired by such hero-

33 ism to also play their part in their own time before they become burdened with the
cares of adult life.

in some circumstances, however much a youth may wish to respond to

34 a call to bahá'í service of a particular kind, he may not be able to do so

35 because he may be in the midst of important academic training that cannot 141.3c

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143 and should not be postponed, he may be dependent on parents who cannot

144 afford to assist him materially both to take time out to engage in a year of

145 service and to return to his academic pursuits later on, or there may be other

146 obstacles. Then there are circumstances in which a youth may find that by
postponing his academic training for a time, he is better able to determine exactly what to do
with his life, if during this time he can make some useful

147 contribution to the faith or to society. There are numerous examples of

such circumstances among bahá'í youth who have found that by engaging

148 in activities of the youth year of service, they were able not only to make

149 valuable contributions to the teaching of the faith or to development proj-

150 ects, but were also able to make up their minds about their life's work. There are also
many youth who prefer to complete their education before offering special services to the f
aith, and this is entirely in order.

The preeminent point drawn from your letter is the importance of bal-

151 ance in judgment and action. The members of the bahá'í institutions can-
152 not escape their duty to urge and stimulate the friends, adult and youth, to serve the
cause, especially in the field of teaching, and in this they are
153 inevitably enthusiastic. of course, individuals differ in their approach and
154 may in some cases be injudicious in their speech; this is to be regretted and dealt with
as instances arise. but those who hear such persons, however
155 much they may be stimulated by them, do also have the individual obliga-
156 tion to make judgments based upon their understanding of the Teachings,
157 of the particular challenge at the moment, and of their circumstances, and should
make their decisions accordingly.

158 As important as it is for parents to exercise their moral authority in as-
159 sisting the youth not to make unwise decisions, it is also incumbent on the parents as
bahá'ís to give due consideration to the significance of the spiri-
160 tual impact of the faith upon the youth and recognize that the youth must
161 have some latitude to respond to the stirrings of their hearts and souls, since they,
beginning at the age of 15, must assume serious spiritual obligations and duties and are
themselves alone ultimately responsible to god for the
162 progress of their own souls. The capacity for mature thinking on the part of
163 youth differs from one to the other and according to age; some attain this
164 ability earlier than others; for some it is delayed. parents are generally in a
165 position to judge these matters more acutely than others and must consider
166 them in their attempts to guide the youth in their families, but the parents
167 must strive to do so in such a way as not to stifle their children's sense of spiritual
responsibility.141.7

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142 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
143 02The house of justice has written numerous letters to the youth which
144 aim at guiding them to achieve a proper balance in their plans and activities.
145 one of these, which was addressed to the bahá'í youth in every land on 10
146 june 1966, may be of particular interest to you and is enclosed herewith.141-2

with deep empathy for you as parents challenged with the onerous task

147 of raising your children in a world beset with unprecedented problems and
difficulties, the house of justice assures you of its ardent prayers in the holy

148 Shrines on your behalf.

149 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

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Resignation of Two Members

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]